

thing, but in this case, it might have been an odd blessing for me. Looking back, I think that's when the seeds of my own need to achieve financial security were sown.

Maybe you're wondering why I'm telling you this story. The truth is that when I deliver tough-minded financial advice, I want you to know where it comes from. I'm a wealthy man now, but at various points in my life, I've experienced the terror of economic insecurity firsthand. I've shared this personal story with you to show that sometimes in life, people may be able to help you out of difficult situations. But there are other times when the only thing that can help you is money. But for money to save you, first, you have to save it.

Beyond saving money in case of catastrophe, my mother was also a savvy spender. Here's the distinction: She was careful with her money, but she wasn't cheap. I remember admiring a Chanel jacket she once wore to Christmas dinner at our place in Boston.

"Great jacket, Mom. Must have cost you a fortune."

"Not this year," she said.

"What do you mean?" I asked.

"Kevin, dear. This jacket is old. I've had it forever."

This surprised me because the jacket was so stylish and beautiful, a black classic box cut. It looked like she'd just picked it up off the rack from that season's new line, but she then told me she'd bought it in the late sixties, twenty years earlier! She spent, at the time, a small fortune—about \$500—for that jacket. We didn't discuss this further, but knowing my mother, she would have saved and thought about this purchase for a long time before actually following through. She would have tried it on a few times, with George there to give her feedback. But the thing is, she wore that jacket for decades. She didn't dry-clean her clothes every time she wore them. She steamed them now and again, to maintain their shape and color. She never flung her clothes on the back of chairs. She always hung them up on hangers. Not everyone can afford Chanel, that must be said, but this example begs some serious math.